Business

1. Samsung just reported its third-quarter operating profit. Given the AI boom is driving enormous demand for chips, how much did Samsung's profit jump compared to the same period last year?

a. Up around 120%, to roughly $20 billion
b. Up 783%, to a record $80 billion
c. Up 45%, to around $8 billion

2. The European car industry is under serious pressure. Which of these best describes what is rattling carmakers at this month's Paris Motor Show?

a. A surge of cheaper, competitive Chinese electric and hybrid vehicles eating into European market share
b. A global shortage of steel pushing up manufacturing costs to record levels
c. New EU safety rules requiring full self-driving capability by 2026

3. Starbucks recently hired Brian Niccol as its new CEO — the same executive who previously ran Chipotle Mexican Grill. What bold strategic move has Starbucks reportedly been exploring since his arrival?

a. Selling its grocery retail business to focus entirely on cafés
b. Launching a chain of drive-through-only locations across rural America
c. Taking over Chipotle Mexican Grill, effectively reuniting Niccol with the burrito chain he used to lead

4. Danish supermarket chain Salling Group is trialling a new type of overnight worker. What has it recently deployed to restock shelves after hours?

a. Humanoid robots that work the night shift while human staff go home
b. AI-powered conveyor systems that automatically sort and shelve products from warehouse to floor
c. University students on a subsidised government work-experience programme

Economics

5. The September US jobs report delivered an unwelcome surprise for a key group. Black unemployment (the share of Black workers actively looking for jobs but unable to find them) rose sharply, reversing a recent encouraging trend. Which of these best describes what had made that earlier trend encouraging?

a. Black unemployment had briefly fallen to its lowest recorded level, suggesting job gains were reaching a broad range of workers
b. Black unemployment had matched the white unemployment rate for the first time in US history
c. Black workers had seen the fastest wage growth of any demographic group for three consecutive years

6. EU countries recently agreed to hand more regulatory powers over financial markets to ESMA, the EU's financial markets watchdog. The goal is to make cross-border investment easier across the bloc. Which of these is NOT a stated reason behind the move?

a. Helping businesses raise money more easily across EU member states
b. Reducing the patchwork of different national rules that complicate cross-border investment
c. Forcing EU pension funds to invest exclusively in European assets

7. The EU recently struck a landmark trade deal with China targeting the car sector. What did China agree to do with its hybrid vehicle exports to Europe?

a. Cut them by more than half over the next four years
b. Cap annual growth at 10% and introduce a minimum price floor
c. Redirect them through third countries to comply with EU tariff rules

8. The World Bank just upgraded its forecast for one Asian economy's GDP growth (the total value of everything a country produces) in 2026. The new figure surprised many observers. What growth rate is now forecast?

a. 4.1% — solid, but roughly in line with regional peers
b. 5.8% — strong, driven mainly by tourism and construction
c. 7.4% — one of the fastest rates of any major economy in the world

General Knowledge

9. Which country is the world's largest producer of coffee by volume?

a. Colombia
b. Brazil
c. Vietnam

10. Which economist, writing in the 18th century, first argued that nations grow wealthier through specialisation and free trade rather than by hoarding gold — an idea that still underpins how most economists think about international commerce today?

a. Adam Smith
b. John Maynard Keynes
c. David Ricardo

Business

1. Samsung just reported its third-quarter operating profit. Given the AI boom is driving enormous demand for chips, how much did Samsung's profit jump compared to the same period last year?

b. Samsung's operating profit rose 783% — nearly ninefold — to a record $80.2 billion for the quarter. That extraordinary leap reflects surging orders for the high-bandwidth memory chips that power AI data centres. Taiwan's TSMC also hit a quarterly sales record over the same period, confirming the AI chip boom is lifting the whole sector, not just one company.

2. The European car industry is under serious pressure. Which of these best describes what is rattling carmakers at this month's Paris Motor Show?

a. Chinese brands have rapidly expanded in Europe, offering electric and hybrid vehicles at prices European manufacturers struggle to match. The 91st Paris Motor Show opened against a backdrop of waning consumer confidence, geopolitical tension over tariffs, and genuine fear that parts of the European automotive industry could be hollowed out. It is the continent's car makers' most uncomfortable motor show in decades.

3. Starbucks recently hired Brian Niccol as its new CEO — the same executive who previously ran Chipotle Mexican Grill. What bold strategic move has Starbucks reportedly been exploring since his arrival?

c. Starbucks has reportedly explored a full takeover of Chipotle, which would bring CEO Brian Niccol back together with the fast-casual chain he ran before joining Starbucks two years ago. If it happened, the deal would create one of the largest multi-brand foodservice companies in the world. Chipotle's market capitalisation sits above $70 billion, making it one of the pricier acquisition targets in the restaurant industry.

4. Danish supermarket chain Salling Group is trialling a new type of overnight worker. What has it recently deployed to restock shelves after hours?

a. Salling Group is testing Hive Robots — humanoid machines — in its stores to handle physically demanding restocking work overnight. The idea is that robots take the night shift so human employees can focus on customer-facing tasks during the day. Denmark is one of Europe's most robotics-friendly countries, partly because high wages make automation economically attractive even for relatively routine tasks.

Economics

5. The September US jobs report delivered an unwelcome surprise for a key group. Black unemployment (the share of Black workers actively looking for jobs but unable to find them) rose sharply, reversing a recent encouraging trend. Which of these best describes what had made that earlier trend encouraging?

a. Economists had taken the recent dip in Black unemployment as a hopeful sign that a tight labour market was lifting workers who are often last to benefit from economic growth. The September reversal was a sharp reminder of how quickly those gains can unwind. Historically, Black unemployment in the US has run at roughly twice the rate for white workers, a gap that persists even in strong economic conditions.

6. EU countries recently agreed to hand more regulatory powers over financial markets to ESMA, the EU's financial markets watchdog. The goal is to make cross-border investment easier across the bloc. Which of these is NOT a stated reason behind the move?

c. Forcing pension funds to invest only in European assets was not part of the deal. The agreement is about streamlining regulation — giving ESMA (the European Securities and Markets Authority) more centralised oversight so that investors and companies face consistent rules rather than navigating 27 different national frameworks. The broader ambition is to build a Capital Markets Union that can compete with the depth of US financial markets.

7. The EU recently struck a landmark trade deal with China targeting the car sector. What did China agree to do with its hybrid vehicle exports to Europe?

a. China agreed to halve its hybrid car sales in the EU — a significant concession aimed at easing European fears that a flood of cheap Chinese vehicles could devastate domestic carmakers. The deal covers hybrid models specifically, alongside existing EU tariffs on Chinese electric vehicles introduced earlier this year. European manufacturers like Volkswagen and Stellantis have been lobbying hard for protection as Chinese brands gain ground fast.

8. The World Bank just upgraded its forecast for one Asian economy's GDP growth (the total value of everything a country produces) in 2026. The new figure surprised many observers. What growth rate is now forecast?

c. The World Bank raised its 2026 growth forecast for Vietnam by 1.1 percentage points to 7.4%, citing stronger-than-expected manufacturing and exports of high-tech and AI-related goods. That would put Vietnam among the fastest-growing economies on the planet. Vietnam has quietly become a major hub for electronics manufacturing as companies diversify supply chains away from China — it is now one of the world's top exporters of smartphones.

General Knowledge

9. Which country is the world's largest producer of coffee by volume?

b. Brazil produces around 35–40% of the world's coffee, more than any other country by a considerable margin. It has held the top spot for over 150 years. Vietnam is the second-largest producer — which connects neatly to its broader manufacturing and export story. Colombia, despite its famous brand, ranks third. The global coffee trade is worth roughly $30 billion a year at export prices.

10. Which economist, writing in the 18th century, first argued that nations grow wealthier through specialisation and free trade rather than by hoarding gold — an idea that still underpins how most economists think about international commerce today?

a. Adam Smith laid out the case for specialisation and free markets in The Wealth of Nations, published in 1776 — the same year as American independence. His concept of the 'invisible hand' argued that individuals pursuing their own interests inadvertently benefit society. David Ricardo later built on Smith's work with the theory of comparative advantage, explaining why trade benefits countries even when one can produce everything more efficiently than the other.